

Common Shallow Sponges of St. Thomas, USVI

Photos by Deborah Gochfeld, IDs by D. Gochfeld & M. Cristina Diaz

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NOAA
CORAL REEF
CONSERVATION PROGRAM



***Mycale laevis*:**
Orange or white, thick encrusting, occurs on undersides of corals and between lobes of corals, clear veins and large oscules



***Mycale laxissima*:**
Purple, red, orange tubes or crust, large oscule with clear collar, surface bumpy or spiny, covered with clear membrane, mucus



***Dictyonella funicularis*:**
Greyish green, very thin, encrusts over coral, rock, algae (shown here) and other sponges, many tiny pores



***Plakortis angulospiculatus*:**
Brown with paler interior, smooth thick encrusting lobes, few large complex oscules



***Svenzea zeai*:**
Brick red to brown, thick encrusting lobes, oscules on small cones, smooth surface, soft, crumbly tan interior



***Svenzea cristinae*:**
Brick red, pink, brown, encrusting or lobes with few large oscules, soft velvety surface with fine lattice pattern, very soft tan interior



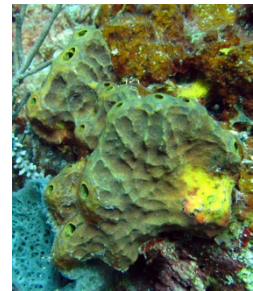
***Ectyoplasia ferox*:**
Bright orange to brown, thick encrusting or massive, oscules on tubes or cones, surface smooth or porous, firm but crumbly



***Aiolochoiria crassa*:**
Yellow, brown, blue, purple & yellow, massive to tubular, rubbery, large rounded bumps on surface, large oscules



***Smenospongia aurea*:**
Green to brown, massive with oscules at ends of cone shaped tubes, honeycomb surface, yellow interior, mucus



***Verongula rigida*:**
Yellow, brown or green, yellow interior, low solitary or grouped tubes or lobes, large oscules on top, ridged surface, blue exudate if damaged



***Ircinia felix*:**
Yellow, orange or brown, massive (picture), cones or branches, bumps on surface, few large oscules, very tough



***Ircinia strobilina*:**
Grey to black, massive globular, surface bumps dense or sparse, tough, oscules on top may be grouped in depressions



***Iotrochota biortulata*:**
Green-black, encrusting or upright, tough, rough surface oscules on top, dark exudate when handled, may host orange zoanthids



***Agelas clathrodes*:**
Bright orange, thick, rubbery, keyhole and round oscules, often fouled, in open or caves



***Desmapsamma anchorata*:**
Light pink, darker interior, thick encrusting with large oscules on tubes or cones, soft, smooth surface, overgrows rock, sponge etc.



***Callyspongia fallax*:**
Grey, purple or blue, small tubes in clusters, large oscules, smooth surface, firm but spongy



***Callyspongia vaginalis*:**
Grey, tan, purple, cluster of tubes or vases, large opening with smooth or spiny rim, surface smooth to small or large spines



***Xestospongia muta*:**
Shades of brown, barrel or vase-shaped, can get very large, brittle, Projections along outer walls



***Cinachyrella* spp.:**
Yellow-orange spherical balls, may be completely fouled, tough, variable number & size of oscules



***Ptilocaulis walpersii*:**
Orange spiny tufts to upright branches or bushes, tough, oscules rarely visible

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***Monanchora arbuscula*:**
Red encrusting, red vein-like canals, transparent white membrane, few large oscules



***Clathria venosa*:**
Grey encrusting, few large oscules at center of star-like clear canal pattern, many tiny pores



***Clathria curacaoensis*:**
Yellow-orange, thinly encrusting over dead coral or in holes, oscules at centers of star-like canal pattern



***Scopalina ruetzleri*:**
Yellow-orange, thin encrusting, soft, pointed peaks due to visible underlying skeletal features, large oscules



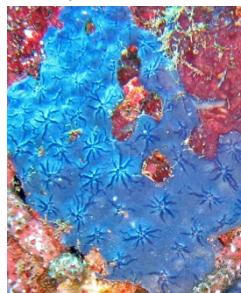
***Spirastrella coccinea*:**
Red or pink with darker specks, encrusting, leathery, vertical surfaces or in holes, small oscules with clear or white collars



***Spirastrella hartmani*:**
Red, pink or orange, encrusting, filmy elevated clear canals radiate from large oscules



***Chondrilla caribensis*:**
Mustard brown, thin smooth encrusting, rubbery, can cover large areas, paler oscules may have star pattern



***Halisarca caerulea*:**
Blue to lavender, thin leathery encrusting, tiny pores, oscules at center of star-like canals



***Neopetrosia proxima*:**
Brown, tan interior, thick crust to upright branching, hard but crumbly, small dispersed oscules



***Neopetrosia dendrocrevacea*:**
Brick to mustard brown, tan interior, crumbly, thick encrusting, bumpy surface with small cones that hold oscules



***Cliona delitrix*:**
Bright orange, bores into coral, round papillae, few large complex oscules with collar



***Niphates erecta*:**
Grey, purple or blue, thick encrusting or upright branches, rough surface, spongy, small oscules often have zoanthids



***Niphates digitalis*:**
Blue-grey, vase, small projections on surface, spiny rim with clear membrane, small oscules inside, may have zoanthids



***Aplysina cauliformis*:**
Purple, grey, or brown, thin tough branches can form thickets, small oscules, also thicker more rigid morphs



***Aplysina fulva*:**
Yellow, thin soft branches can form thickets if large, scattered oscules, blue exudate if handled



***Aplysina insularis*:**
Yellow, solitary or groups of tubes with large oscules, thin projections, soft, blue exudate if handled



***Aplysina archeri*:**
Lavendar, solitary or groups of tubes with large oscules, smooth or bumpy surface, tough



***Amphimedon compressa*:**
Maroon to bright red, thick, compressible, encrusting or branches, oscules can have elevated rims, red exudate if squeezed



***Amphimedon complanata*:**
Black erect branches or small lumps, compressible but hard to tear, smooth, small oscules, dark exudate if squeezed



***Hyrtios proteus*:**
Black massive with bumpy surface, tan interior, compressible but hard to tear, no exudate, small oscules if any